

"TIGER'S DEDICATION TO EVERYTHING HE DOES IS SOMETHING I REALLY ADMIRE. HE IS A COMPLETE PACKAGE," SAYS THE ACTOR'S *WAR* CO-STAR, HRITHIK ROSHAN

When his debut film *Heropanti* (2014) released, it earned Rs 72.6 crore, unheard of for a newcomer. The *Baaghi* series (2016—) has been a blockbuster too, having collected 524 crore. Jai Hemant Shroff started being called 'Tiger' by his father Jackie, because as a baby, he used to bite everyone. Today, by the admission of even his co-stars, Tiger bites into every single role wholeheartedly.

Kriti Sanon, his leading lady from his debut film to his last release, *Ganapath* (2023)—which was, incidentally, his lowest-earning film ever—has this to say: "Once Tiger is convinced that something has to be done, there is no doubt that he will raise the bar when he finally does it. Whether it is a challenging action sequence or a complicated dance routine, once he knows he has to do it, he will ace it! So many times, he has actually mastered a dance step in just one go and then is assisting the choreographers in helping others do it! He's always that good student in a classroom who will master a math problem and then teach the weaker students!"

On his part, Tiger admits that he wants to "be his own competition", adding, "I want to prove myself with every film! I want to entertain people better, push myself more and more. The audiences have accepted me as an action hero and that's what they expect of me. So, I just try to raise the bar of action with every film I do. The stakes get higher and higher, the premise, the geography, the budgets and the landscapes get bigger and bigger. So, it's tough to reinvent myself in this space. But I think there is still so much to explore."

It is perhaps because of this tenacity that despite some lows like *Student of The Year 2* (2019) and *Ganapath*, Tiger refuses to back down. The 33-year-old actor is perhaps the most prominent face of action in Bollywood, going by his releases for the next two years. Tiger's unwavering consistency and magnetic appeal further solidify his status as a bankable star.

It is also superstars who have been co-actors with Tiger who are full of praise for him. A lot was written about the camaraderie between Hrithik Roshan and Tiger, when the duo worked in 2019's *War*. "When I first met him, it was like a mutual admiration club. I have literally seen him grow and feel just so proud of him. Tiger's dedication to everything that he does is something I really admire. He is a complete package. I think Tiger's biggest USP is how he has made his place in the hearts of people of all age groups—that is something I can't compliment him enough for!" says Hrithik.

It is not just as a proud and indulgent father that Jackie Shroff says in his trademark style, "I used to think that non-stop three shifts in my time was hard work, but *bhidu, yahaan toh mere bachche ne hi mujhe mehnat kya hoti hai, ye sikha diya*! [my son has taught me what hard work is!]"

Responding to comparisons with Bruce Lee and Michael Jackson, Tiger says, "I am what I am because of all these icons. I push